African Sun

October, 1991

WELCOME FIRST YEARS

To the first year students across the African Diaspora whose names were not listed in the "Welcome to the Class of 95" (African Sun, Sept. 1991):

We would like to extend to you a warm welcome to the Black community. We wish you the best in a successful career at Brown and hope you use your years here to the best of your ability and to prepare Brown for the continuous arrival of future Black students of all socio-economic backgrounds.

HISTORICAL EVENTS IN OCTOBER

3rd, 1904— Mary McLeod Bethune opened Daytona Normal and Industrial School in Daytona Beach, Florida. In 1923 the school merged with Cookman Institute and became Bethune-Cookman College.

3rd, 1949— WERD, the first Black-owned radio station, opened in Atlanta, Georgia.

4th, 1864— New Orleans Tribune, the first Black daily newspaper, was founded by Dr. Louis C. Roudanez. The newspaper published in both English and French, started as a triweekly but soon became an influential daily.

16th, 1901— Booker T. Washington dined at the White House with President Roosevelt and was criticized in the South for doing so.

16th, 1968— John Carlos and Tommie Smith staged a Black Power demonstration on the victory stand after placing first and third in the 200-meter dash at the Olympics in Mexico City. Carlos and Smith were protesting racism in America. They had their medals stripped for doing so.

17th, 1888—Capital Savings Bank of Washington, D.C., the first Black owned bank opened in Washington, D.C.

19th, 1943— The Theater Guild presentation of *Othello* opened at Shubert Theater with Paul Robeson in the title role. The production ran for 296 performances and set a record for a Shakespearean drama on Broadway.

23rd, 1945— Brooklyn Dodgers signed Jackie Robinson and sent him to their leading farm club in the International League, the Montreal Royals.

26th, 1934— At a New York City conference, representatives of the NAACP and the American Fund for Public Service coordinated a legal campaign against segregation and discrimination. Charles H. Houston, vice-dean of the Howard University Law School, was named Director of the NAACP campaign.

28th, 1914— Omega Psi Phi Fraternity, Incorporated was founded at Howard University.

(Reference: Before the Mayflower, Lerone Bennett, Jr. 1982)

NEWS

HAITI

According to the New York Amsterdam News, in what has been referred to as "the law of the jungle", Haitian troops have reportedly forced its legislators to appoint Haiti's senior Supreme Court Justice Joseph Norette as President, replacing the popularly elected Fr. Aristide. The action of the troops has sparked widespread protests among Haitians and Haitian-Americans.

Though Aristide was accused of allowing "human rights violations" to take place, the majority of Haitians are openly supporting his attempt to regain power. Aristide, having once served Haiti's poor as a Catholic priest, won the support and respect of many through his efforts to strengthen ties between Haitians and Africans, as well as African-Americans. The events have also sparked much discussion among Haitians about the role of the Haitian military.

THE APOLLO LIVES ON

For everyone from Sinbad to Sammy Davis Jr. to the Supremes and Sandman Sims, the Apollo Theater in Harlem has been a standing symbol of the accomplishments of African-Americans in the entertainment industry - and it will live on. This month, despite the Apollo's recent economic crisis and near shut-down, activists, community leaders, politicians, and entrepreneurs have been able to put the theater back on its feet. In particular, the refocusing of the Apollo into a non-profit entity, the leadership of Harlem Congressman Charles Rangel, a seven million-dollar loan from the Urban Development Corporation, other loans and relieved debts helped to make this possible. So, once again audiences can shout out, "It's Showtime!"

FILM ON BLACK SOLDIERS

WNET-Channel 13, a part of the Public Broadcasting System, is in the process of filming the documentary "Liberators: Fighting on Two Fronts in World War II", about the Black battalions that helped to free thousands of Jews from German concentration camps at Buchenwald and Dachau. Though not very well known, the fact remains that all-Black battalions like the 761st and 183rd played a "major role" in capturing European towns. Although they were omitted from media reports and subsequent war dramas such as *Patton*, the Black battalions received hundreds of purple hearts for their efforts.

BLACKS SMOKE LESS

Whether due to the rising cost of cigarettes, anti-smoking messages in the media, or "new found concern" about the health of Blacks, the rate of smoking among Black teenagers has dropped appreciably over the past decade, according to a recent study which was a part of the federal Youth Risk Behavior Survey. The study also showed that Black high school students smoke 2 1/2 times less than their white counterparts. According to Gary Giovino of the Office of Smoking and Health at the Federal Center for Disease Control in Atlanta, one reason for the gap may be that young Black women are less overtly concerned about weight control than their white counterparts, and may be "less tempted to use smoking as a method of controlling appetite."

(Reference: New Amsterdam News, New York.)

CAMPUS NEWS

BLACK STUDENT WEEKEND

Brown University will host its first ever recruiting weekend for Black students, November 9th-11th. An anonymous donor has contributed money toward increasing the matriculation rate of Black students to Brown. A large portion of the donation will be used to see that Black students are given the chance to come visit Brown and view its academic side. If you were unable to attend the emergency meeting on October 17th, but are still interested in housing or helping out, please call Heather Grady at 863-6136 or Jeremi Duru at 863-6199. The matriculation rate of Black students to Brown is steadily falling so we must all make a collective effort to make Black students interested in coming to Brown feel welcome. If you cannot house for this weekend, there are various things throughout the year that can be done. For more information, call Heather or Jeremi. The success of this weekend is upon our shoulders. Please show your support by volunteering your services.

WELCOME BACK "CAMP BRUNO"

Upon hearing that the Brown Administration is thinking of raising the tuition yet again by 6.3%, I have to question who the administration thinks will be attending this prestigeous Ivy League institution by the time the year 2000 rolls around.

With the continued trend of 6.3% tuition increases, the tuition bill will be $19,526 by the time the Class of 1995 graduates. Presently it is $16,256. By the time the Class of 1995 graduates, the total cost of Brown will be $26,233, which includes only tuition, room, board, health services fee, and the student activities fee. Presently the total cost of Brown is $21,946. In relative terms this all means that each member of the Class of 1995 will have to pay approximately **$100,000** for a college education at Brown University.

If this scenario continues to unfold without any changes in the financial aid system, Brown will in fact become just another institution that is off-limits to most of Black community. Economic discrimination is part of the new and subtle racism that is ever present in our society. There is no longer a need to put up signs "Whites Only" or yell racial slurs. Just raise the price high enough at the "Camp Bruno" country club and all will be well on this campus once more. Think about it.

—Eric Schlueter, '93

FAYNESE MILLER RECEIVES TENURE

On September 23rd, Faynesse Miller became a tenured Brown professor in the Education department. Professor Miller is the ~~fourth~~ third woman of color to be tenured at Brown—EVER! Miller graduated from Hampton University and later studied at Texas Christian and Yale Universities. Congratulations to Professor Miller and best wishes for a continued success at Brown. Nice to see some Black Brown faculty moving up instead of out.

COLORED GIRLS PACK HOUSE

During the month of September, the Production Workshop was the site for one of this years most moving plays. *For Colored Girls Who Have Considered Suicide When the Rainbow is Enuf* was written by Ntozake Shange and directed by Angela Robinson. It showcased the dynamic talents of, Nicole Brewer, Aunjanue Ellis, Ti Johnson, Yoruba Richen, and Eder Williams. *Colored Girls* explored the hardships endured by Black women, touching upon such issues as unfaithful lovers, coming of age, and dysfunctional families. Many of the women who attended felt that the play's message evoked strong feelings of sistershood—they were not alone in their struggle; however, several men felt as though the entire male gender was singled out and blamed for every problem any woman has ever experienced. Despite the disparity in feelings, the audiences—both male and female—felt that *Colored Girls* was an extraordinarily powerful play, true to life.

Word-of-mouth rave reviews spread across campus like wildfire as students waited in line anywhere from one to three hours in hopes of getting a ticket to the performance. *Colored Girls* opened every night to a filled to capacity audience with approximately one hundred students being turned away each night.

---J. Omari Johnson

THOUGHTS AND OPINIONS

The following are the thoughts and opinions of individuals in Brown's Black community. They do not necessarily reflect the opinions or views of the African Sun or the Organization of United African People. Keep that in mind as you read. Enjoy.

for colored boys who've been dogged by colored girls

Colored girls, we need to talk:
I am so tired of sistas moaning and groaning
About how the Black man has oppressed the Black woman.
Throughout all their recollections of sisterly struggles,
Black women never seem to remember
(Or realize, or maybe admit)
That they have done some oppressing of their own on the Black man.
They point their fingers at Black males at large and scream,
"You raped me, you beat me, you cheated on me,
You abandoned me and our five kids,"
All this accompanied by a finger snap and that fierce Black female attitude.
Well, excuse you, Miss Thang,
But I ain't raped you, I ain't beat you, I ain't cheated on you,
And I definitely ain't abandoned you and some five illegitimate kids,
So just kill that shit right now.
In fact, I ain't never even had a chance to do these things
Since you always diss good brothers like me
For the flashy fools that end up doggin' you time after time,
And yet you keep going back to them
And just leave me sittin' on the curb like a Hefty in heat.
Oh, yeah, I forgot,
You do come to me sometimes,
Like when you want to use me to make your dog jealous,
Or when you want to use me to support you while your dog is out chasing every accessible freak in town,
Or when you want to use me to reaffirm you self-image as a potent seductress.
But just because you sometimes decide to throw me a bone
Doesn't make me a dog.
However, I've seen a leash strapped to your neck quite often.
Granted, some brothers out there are trifling,
But face it, some of y'all sistas are just as canine as the fellas.
And you wonder why we call you bitch.

— a dogged colored boy

SHOW SOME *RESPECT*

Black men, it has been called to my attention that we do not act like gentlemen towards the Black women here at Brown; that we act more like uncouth, horny dogs rather than the refined, Morehouse-type men we should be. I can only speak for myself, but if these above statements are true then we deserve to be in a kennel rather than at Brown. Black women, regardless of how they look, speak, or think, should be treated with the utmost respect. If that means going out of your way to help one of them, then go out of your way. Remember men, we would not be here if it were not for the Black women in our lives.

Now Black women, do not think that I have forgotten about you. The world in general, and this campus, in particular, would be a whole lot more livable if you would stop downgrading us to the level of dogs. Respect is a two way street, and you must give a little to get a little. *All of the Black men on this campus are not dogs*. Most of us are still puppies. If we both start giving each other a little respect and getting to know one another rather than incessantly complaining about the "tired or snooty women" or "the doggish men", then maybe we won't have a need for the annual, always enlightening, "Black Male - Female Relationships on Brown's Campus" forums.

—Roy Carter, Jr. '94

UNTITLED

--When millions of Black men and women were tossed into the bloody waters of the Atlantic, Black babies died along with them.

--When the soil of Potter's field becomes increasingly crowded everyday, crowded with the tiny caskets of little Black babies who have not yet lived, we see that Black babies are dying.

--When crack, AIDS, poor health care, poverty and the devastating effects of colonialism are bringing about the untimely deaths of thousands of Black babies yearly - across the diaspora - we indeed see that Black babies are dying.

--Yet why is it that when young Black women with no where else to turn, allow their bodies to be invaded and the lives of the tiny Black babies inside them to be aborted, no one seems to care for the woman or the child?

--Have we become so engrossed in blindly following the White women's crusade - which seems all too focused on their own oppression by White men and not on *our* struggles as a people - that we have forgotten what is really going on here?

--While White women crowd the steps of the State House and the White House demanding the right to abort, it is Black women who crowd the halls of medical centers getting the abortions. (This goes without mentioning the other extreme: the tactics of "pro lifers" which often serve to further traumatize women who are receiving abortions.)
--Am I receiving justice or equal treatment when I walk into a local clinic in a Black community, and I see "Abortion: $50" carelessly sketched on a piece of torn cardboard?
--Does this "right" belong to me, whose womanhood and dignity have not even been recognized since 1619?
--And are we so engrossed in the "right to choose" and the right to "terminate unwanted pregnancies" that we have forgotten WHOSE pregnancies are being called unwanted and WHOSE children are being referred to as mere "burdens in society" and WHOSE children are, in fact, being aborted?
--Whether we agree with the "pro choicers" or "pro lifers", or whatever the established groups are called, we must - without passing judgement on one another - realize that it is *our* people who are most affected by this issue....and begin to deal with it from there.

---Olufunmilayo Gittens, '95

COMING OUT

I am tired of being an invisible person in the African-American community. As I begin the process of coming out, I am weary of the possibility of my sexuality and race becoming polarized facets of my individuality. I refuse to accept disrespectful behavior from fellow brothers and sisters. I am happy to say that Brown is an environment in which I feel comfortable living with all of my differences. I want people to understand that I am African-American, Gay, male and very much at ease with my total being.

The presence of "The Next Thing" on campus has allowed me to finally feel a part of the Third World Community. I can share experiences and talk at ease with Lesbian, Gay and Bisexual students of color. But we continue to remain invisible in the Third World community due to lack of your acceptance. Somehow my existence is not fully acknowledged if I feel silenced or ill at ease at an OUAP meeting. I hate being an invisible man. I challenge you to be supportive as more students of color "come out" of the closet and want your respect.

Peace out.

Ako

STUDENT SECURITY?

This letter incited the cover story on the shuttle incident in the Brown Daily Herald. I cooperated with the BDH under the assumption that both a BDH article and my letter would be printed; however, only the article was printed. I was not out to attack the driver; his name was not even mentioned in my original letter. Because he represented the campus shuttle, his actions were taken on a broader level as institutionalized racism. That was my point which was overlooked by the BDH.

In the Tuesday, September 10th issue of the Brown Daily Herald, an editorial stated, "Who the hell gave any student group the right to compromise campus security?" Whose right "to party to culture overrides safety?" These questions urged us to address the possibility of irresponsible student behavior, yet what happens when irresponsibility and wrongdoing falls with the department of campus security? This was exactly the situation on Saturday night (or Sunday morning) at 3:40 am, 9/15/91.

It was day two of a get-together/slumber party that my roommate and I had thrown, and because of the late hour, my friends, exhausted, were ready to leave. Due to the time of night and the length that they had to walk (from Barbour to the Quad and Pembroke campus), my friends decided to utilize the escort service. What happened then was a disgrace.

When the escort service arrived, my friends were greeted with hostility, apathy, rudeness and disrespect. Whether or not it pertained to the color of their skins is a good question. As I stood in the doorway expecting to see my friends off, I heard comments such as "If you don't like it, get the hell out!" The driver flat out refused to take one person for no reason, and refused to transport the whole party even though they were going in the same direction. He said to another, "Do you really think **you** need protection?! Do you **really** think that **you** can get mugged?!" My friends could not comprehend his attitude, and after trying to talk to him sensibly were responded to with, "I'll call the cops."

Since the dispute was not resolved, the Brown cops were summoned. Upon their arrival, the escort driver blatantly denied any wrongdoing, stating that he had a "long night." The cops escorted some of my friends home, the others walked, as they justifiably refused to go in the escort.

The waves of anger and futility that swept through me as I stood and watched that scene made me realize that even the liberal haven of Brown is no protection from racism. When a Brown student cannot utilize a service of Brown, the escort service, then I think that department needs to reevaluate its purpose. The escort service should help students avoid unnecessary harassment and stress, not augment it.

My friends are planning on filing a complaint because nobody deserves the treatment that they received. Maybe people need to stop exploiting the cases of student irresponsibility, especially by singling out a certain race, and look at the problems within the not so perfect Brown bureaucracies. On that level, discrimination is institutionalized; on the contrary, tuition is universal.

—Tanya Southerland, '95

UNCLE (SUPREME COURT JUSTICE) THOM(AS)

By supporting Clarence Thomas's confirmation I feel as though I am jeopardizing my individual rights and that the country as a whole is jeopardizing its future. Given the conservative swing of our country and this post-Reagan, Bush administration, our executive and judiciary sectors of government are on the verge sending this country back to the 1950's. When this country's women are in danger of losing their right to choose, when there are movements to overturn civil rights measures, and when there is talk of abandoning affirmative action, I am extremely leery of anyone like Thomas. Throughout the Senate Judiciary Hearings, Thomas gave no clear indication about where he stands on *Roe v. Wade*, civil rights, or affirmative action, but his history as a judge leaves me with chills because his rulings have been extremely right-wing . During his tenure as chairman of the EEOC, Thomas enacted policies which undermined legal protection for minorities, women, and the elderly. Once he takes his seat in the Supreme Court, he will possess the power to erode the hard-won civil liberties of American minorities.

The same man who now sides with the party that is attempting to rescind so many of the measures that promote equality and opportunity for minorities has directly benefited from them. Does Thomas think that he singlehandedly pulled himself up by his bootstraps? Thomas has faced poverty and the humiliation of discrimination throughout his life, and these experiences *should* give him a greater insight into understanding the restrictive and repressive consequences of an ultra-conservative Court.

Thomas's lack of insight also transcends into the realm of constitutional philosophy, another reason to dread his appointment. During the congressional hearings, his naivete regarding constitutional issues such as separation of power and the First Amendment became glaringly obvious. He failed to prove adequate familiarity in dealing with legal issues; basically he lacks the experience necessary to sit on the Supreme Court. However, some of his supporters were willing to overlook his shortcomings on the basis of his color. He reaped the benefits from the fruit that he so vehemently opposes. Said Senator Arlen Specter, "I think it's very important that an African-American be on the court now. Within the chambers of those nine justices...they [need] to hear the views of African-Americans in this country." Yes, Clarence Thomas adds diversity to the bench; however, whose views does he represent? I doubt that Thomas's views truly reflect the majority of African-Americans.

By nominating a Black man, President Bush thought he'd win Black and white liberal support. There is only one problem; Judge Thomas is conservative. He doesn't have the Black community's interests in mind. The belief that only Black people can speak for other Blacks is over. The days of blindly supporting any candidate purely on the basis of color and totally negating principles have vanished. We want someone who will protect what generations before us strived for and what we on a daily basis are still trying to achieve—equality, opportunity, and choice.

In light of Thomas's confirmation, the Black community as well as other minority groups will be ill at ease until Thomas actually takes action. As a Supreme Court Justice, he is free from political strings; thus, he may freely move across party lines. Although Thomas's judgements in the past have been all too hypocritically right-wing, his intense, enduring trial must have opened his eyes to his environment and helped him to understand the importance of upholding and protecting certain rights. Now is the time for Thomas to recall *who* he is, remember *where* he is from, reevaluate his judicial philosophy, and ***do the right thing!***

—J. Omari Johnson, '95

CALENDER OF UPCOMING EVENTS

Oct. 23rd-"The Next Thing" meeting-Commons Room, Alumnae Hall 9 p.m. "The Next Thing" is a group for gay, lesbian, bisexual, and questioning people of color. Questions??-Erika at 863-5883

Oct. 26-1st Friday Night Blues Cabaret in George H. Bass Auditorium (GHB) of Churchill sponsored by the Afro-Am. department, Rites and Reason, and Kulcha Kollective (ARK 2). There will be an open stage for impersonations, poetry and drama. There will be food served and a jazz/blues band.

Oct. 30-ASA/OUAP Forum on "Bridging the gaps: Africans and African-Americans" 7:30p.m. Emery-Wooley Lounge

Nov. 1-Rites and Reason reading of "What Does It Mean to be Human"- GHB Auditorium

Nov. 2- SOCA dance, 10p.m. Emery-Wooley Lounge $2

Nov. 3- OUAP Meeting. **YOU DOWN WIT OUAP? "YEAH YOU KNOW ME"** 2p.m. TWC- **"DAMN SKIPPY I'M WIT IT!!"**

Nov. 5-Black women meeting for discussion on future united Black women's coalition, 7:30 p.m. Petteruti Lounge

Nov. 8-10- "Anowa," play by Ghanian playwright Ama Ata Aidoo. GHB Auditorium Nov. 8th-4 p.m., 9th-8 p.m., 10th-4 p.m.

Nov. 9-11- Black Student Weekend—Be sure to house!

Nov. 22-24- "The Owl Answers," a laboratory theater presentation in GHB Auditorium.

EDITORS' NOTE

The African Sun is a Black student publication through the Organization of United African People. We encourage you as individuals, and as organizations to submit articles, essays, poems, announcements, or opinions dealing with the Black community at Brown or in the world. All submissions for the November issue are due by November 10. All submissions for December are due by November 22. We look forward to your participation. Questions?? Contact Melanie 351-2792 or Nadirah 351-9007.

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